Faces and Threats

Marc Alexander · Week 3

1 Ends

Will

Rationality

Face

2 Negative Face

- **the need for privacy**
- **the freedom to pursue your own goals**
- freedom of action and freedom from imposition
- the desire for one's actions be unimpeded by others



FIGURE 1 A close-up of the right-hand side of the composite face: eye, cheek and grey stubble

3 Positive Face

- **the need for social approval**
- one's positive consistent self-image, including the desire that this self-image be appreciated and approved of
- the desire that one's wants be desirable to at least some others



FIGURE 2 A close-up of the left-hand side of the composite face: a wrinkled eye, nose and cheek

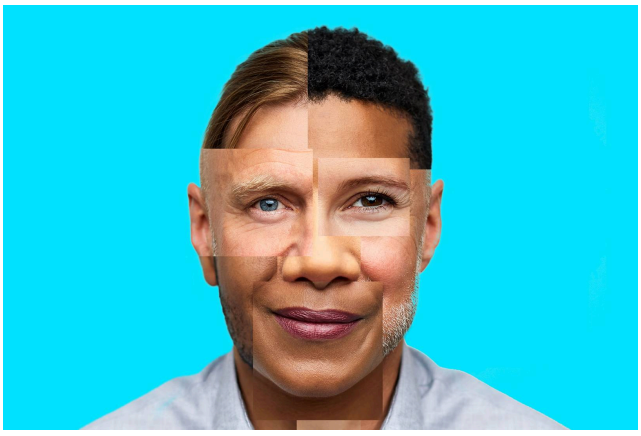


FIGURE 3 A composite portrait on a bright cyan ground: one face assembled from pieces of the faces of several different people

politeness

(facework)

Face Threatening Acts

FTA

4 FTA

- **negative face**: *the need for privacy and the freedom to pursue your own goals*
  - Linguistically threatened by: INTRUSIONS, COMMANDS, REQUESTS, ADVICE, REMINDERS, etc
- **positive face**: *the need for social approval*
  - Linguistically threatened by: INSULTS, ANGER, REFUSALS, INTERRUPTIONS, INATTENTION, etc

5 Rate of imposition

Can I borrow your…

pen
car
dog
wife/husband
life savings

6 Social distance

Dear Professor Smith, We haven't met but I wonder if I could possibly ask you…

Hi Fraser, Can I ask a question about…

Hey nerd, what's up with…

7 Power relationship

Excuse me, ma'am, but would it be all right if I were to close the window?

Mind me closing the window?

You there, close the bloody window!



FIGURE 4 The weight with FTA on it equals rate of imposition plus social distance plus power relationship; beneath it the formula W sub FTA equals R plus D sub S to H plus P sub H to S

Politeness

FTA
- commit the FTA
  - directly
    - baldly (without redressive action)
    - with politeness
  - indirectly
- don't commit the FTA

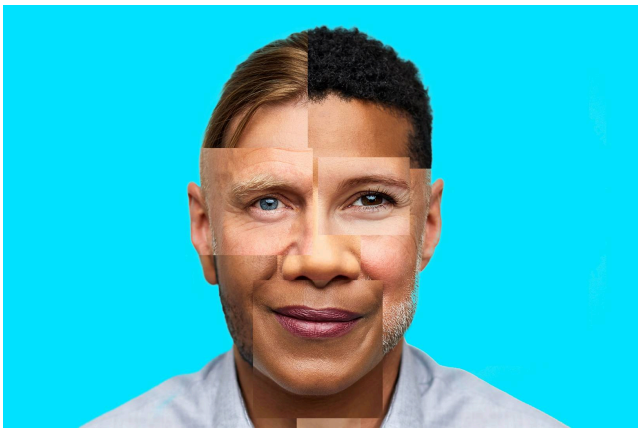


FIGURE 5 A composite portrait on a bright cyan ground: one face assembled from pieces of the faces of several different people

Negative Politeness

Aimed at negative face: not infringing another's domain and minimizing the impact of the FTA

Positive Politeness

Aimed at positive face: sociable behaviour, such as compliments, which show an awareness of the hearer's needs and point of view

8 Negative Politeness

politeness strategy	linguistic form
Don't presume	Question
Give hearer options	Be pessimistic
Minimize FTA	Make explicit rate of imposition
Redress other wants	Go on record as owing or forgiving a debt
Communicate desire not to impose	Apologise
Disassociate from imposition	Avoid first-person pronouns, state as general rule

9 Positive Politeness

politeness strategy	linguistic form
Claim common ground	Attend to hearer's interests, seek agreement, joke, state common ground
Show admiration/interest	Exaggerate interest/approval/sympathy for hearer

politeness strategy	linguistic form
Convey cooperation	Show concern for hearer's wants, give reasons
Claim reflexivity	Be optimistic, include the hearer in the activity
Fulfil one of hearer's desires	Give something to hearer (eg things, sympathy, understanding, cooperation)